

a few Airbus 321s. That order book is still intact. When Covid-19 hit us in early 2020, we had a fleet of 40 aircraft. Right now, we are at about 51 aircraft. We would probably [have been] closer to 60 if Covid-19 was not there and would have hit the 70-aircraft number sometime in early 2023. Now that gets pushed by maybe a year. What we would say is that the pandemic has delayed plans, rather than saying that we have cancelled plans.

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The introduction of Boeing 787s will probably throw up a situation where a non-stop flight to the US or Australia is a reality at some point...

It's something we are looking at. We had ordered six Boeing 787s, of which two are already with us. An ultra-long-haul flight requires certain things such as a thrust rating for the engine and a crew bunk, which the current aircraft don't come equipped with. But yes, there are definitely potential opportunities. We are doing some studies and reviews to see whether that makes sense. The routes that we currently operate with the Boeing 787s in Europe have been doing phenomenally well. The cargo carried on the routes has been equally supportive.

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How do you see your expansion story in the

domestic sector playing out?

Currently, we cover about 30 cities within India, which is decent. The frequency or the proportion changes because there is a lot more capacity deployed on Category I or metro routes as compared to the others. Most of the major cities or catchments in the country have been covered. There will be an increase in frequencies on

months ahead, do you see geopolitical uncertainties and high fuel prices impacting ticket sales in the near- and medium-term?

Today, we are operating in a very dynamic market, and it is difficult to predict the consequences of various external factors like the current geopolitical situation in Ukraine. As an airline, we can only stay agile and cope with their

needs to be done with fuel prices running rampant at the moment.

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The post-pandemic period has witnessed several companies across sectors imbibing technology in a big way. Tell us something about your initiatives.

In the good old days of pre-Covid-19, we used to have situations where people would just walk in one hour before the flight to check in. Those days are gone. The percentage of people checking in through the website or mobile before the pandemic was between 20-30 per cent. Now it's about 95 per cent. So essentially, everyone has embraced technology. Technology has helped in facilitating some of these decisions and user behaviours. Secondly, unlike in the past, checking in bags has also become electronic. When you drop your bags, you get an SMS on your registered [mobile] number for reference.

There has been a lot of investment in many of these automation technologies in streamlining human resources, procurement and finance. Ultimately, what we need is a situation where the customer does not need to call us. This can be achieved either through mobile or the website. For example, we have a chatbot now on our website. **BT**

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PEOPLE WHO HAVE TRAVELLED THE WORLD ARE WILLING TO PAY A LITTLE BIT MORE FOR A SLIGHTLY MORE COMFORTABLE FLIGHT

some existing points, plus a little bit more expansion into certain other white spaces, which we think are important. A lot of this is also to facilitate and feed into our international market. The fact that we have international flights requires feeders from different parts of the country.

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Amid all the bullish forecasts of growth returning to India's civil aviation space in the

direct and indirect impact on the aviation ecosystem.

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What is the component of ATF in your overall operational costs?

Fuel for any airline in India is between 35-40 per cent [of the operational costs]. We are very thankful that the civil aviation minister has persuaded some of the states to bring down taxes on ATF. And that's a very welcome move. But of course, more